

Tablets do so much more

No longer just a one-purpose device, says Lenovo's Pankaj Harjai

Siddharth Chauhan | editor@digit.in

For years, Indian consumers saw tablets as “big phones without the phone bit” or “budget PCs without the power.” The pandemic changed that. What was once an occasional-use gadget for reading PDFs or streaming movies became a lifeline for education, remote work, and yes, binge-watching.

Pankaj Harjai, APJ Leader & Director of Tablets & Smart Devices at Lenovo, is unequivocal about why the category has resurged. “The tablet is no longer a one-purpose device,” he says. “It’s used for meetings, learning, productivity, entertainment, and even gaming. People have realised it can fit into so many parts of their lives.”

Beyond the “big phone” stereotype

Remote learning and work created an urgency, but Harjai argues that sustained demand comes from product evolution. “Form factors have changed. We’ve moved from basic slates to devices with pen support, detachable keyboards, and performance that can rival laptops,” he explains.

OTT streaming exploded and people wanted bigger screens than their phones but didn’t want to be

tethered to a TV. Gaming, once a desktop-and-console-only affair, has found a home on the tablet form factor due to cooler thermals than a phone, more screen real estate, and increasingly high-refresh displays. Productivity, though, is the dark horse. “For a lot of professionals, the tablet has become a must-have second device. In some cases, it’s even the

first,” Harjai admits, pointing to his own Yoga Tab Plus.

Harjai outlines what he calls Lenovo’s four “swim lanes”: productivity, entertainment, gaming, and education.

Each of the “lanes” has a clear flagship: AI-enabled models for productivity, the JBL-equipped Tab Plus for entertainment, Legion for gaming, and stylus-ready Yoga for education.

The premium shift

While many tablets in India are priced under ₹25,000, and that’s still the volume sweet spot, Harjai concedes. But ASPs (average selling prices) have doubled for Lenovo in the past three years. Why? “Two years ago, we asked consumers in 15 countries what they wanted in a tablet. They told us: more power, better screens, larger batteries, and they were willing to pay for it,”

The Lenovo Tab Yoga Plus, priced starting at ₹49,999, is proof. “We were pleasantly surprised by the love it’s received. People saw the value: personalised AI that learns, on-device knowledge retrieval, and hardware that enhances creativity. Today’s consumer is smart,” he says, leaning in. “If they see value, they’ll pay.”

Why AI is better on a tablet

Tablets, Harjai argues, are inherently interactive devices: “A tablet has more ways to interact with the user than a PC. Touch, pen, keyboard, cameras. That’s why AI on a tablet makes more sense than on a PC for certain use cases. It’s a canvas for interaction.”

He cites practical scenarios: a coach getting analytics tailored to a player’s style; a creator whose device learns their design preferences; a salesperson whose notes sync intelligently between laptop and tablet..

Tablets as “first” devices

Harjai smiles when I ask if tablets are still seen as “secondary devices.” For him, they’re not. “If you ask me personally, my tablet is my first device. I work on it, watch movies, take notes, even run AI workflows,” Harjai says.

Lenovo wants more people to think like that. Which is why pen compatibility is now standard across its new range. “Most competitors don’t offer that across models. It’s a differentiator for students and professionals.”

The road ahead

Harjai’s focus is clear: expand AI capabilities, strengthen Smart Connect across Lenovo PCs, Motorola phones, and tablets, and introduce products that go beyond screen upgrades. “Consumers want more, and they’re telling us exactly what that is.”

“The consumer is demanding, and that’s a good thing. It keeps us improving every day,” Harjai says. **d**

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